AKAMAI CLOUD AI HACKATHON · LIVE AUDIENCE DEMO

PITCH OR DITCH

Three people pitch the most ridiculous startup idea they can think of. An AI investor challenges each one, proposes a pivot, and asks the room whether they would fund it.

Model **Qwen3-4B** Served by **vLLM on Akamai LKE** LLM calls per pitch **1** Code **~140 lines of Python**

THE IDEA

An AI demo anyone in the room gets in five seconds

Most AI demos ask the audience to watch. Pitch or Ditch asks them to play. The audience writes the input, the model performs, and the audience decides the outcome with a show of hands. There is nothing to explain: everyone knows what an investor pitch looks like.

HOW A ROUND WORKS

Pitch, roast, pivot, vote

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STEP 1

Pitch

A founder from the audience types their ridiculous idea.

STEP 2

Roast

Victoria Vault, the AI investor, gives a gut reaction and three holes in the plan.

STEP 3

Pivot

She proposes a smarter version with a new name, and names her offer.

STEP 4

Vote

The room votes fund or ditch by show of hands. After three pitches, a scoreboard picks the winner.

FROM A REAL RUN

Two verdicts, unedited model output

Jordan: LinkedIn for dogs: professional networking for good boys

FUNDED

FIRST REACTION

Aww, that's sweet. But can dogs actually network?

THE CHALLENGE

- Market: Who networks with dogs?
- Money: How do you monetize a dog's resume?
- Risk: Dogs might get jealous of other dogs.

THE PIVOT

Maybe "Paw-tner", a platform for dogs to connect with other dogs for walks, training, and maybe even dating.

ASK THE AUDIENCE

Would you fund Paw-tner for $500k with 10% equity?

Leo: Blockchain-verified socks so you never lose one again

DITCHED

FIRST REACTION

That's a sock in the eye to forgetfulness.

THE CHALLENGE

- Market: People already lose socks, but few care about blockchain.
- Money: Socks are cheap, but blockchain infrastructure is expensive.
- Risk: Socks can't be divided into tokens, so the model is flawed.

THE PIVOT

We'll turn socks into NFTs, each with a unique story and QR code. Call it "SockChain."

Audience: 15 fund / 4 ditch

ASK THE AUDIENCE

Would you fund SockChain for $50k in equity?

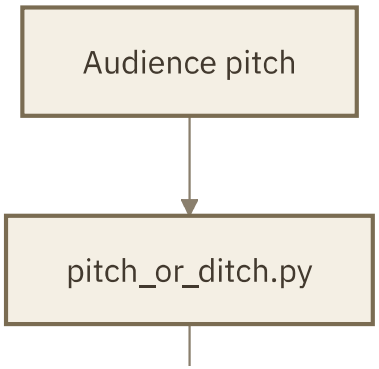
Audience: 2 fund / 18 ditch

FINAL SCOREBOARD · TEST SHOW

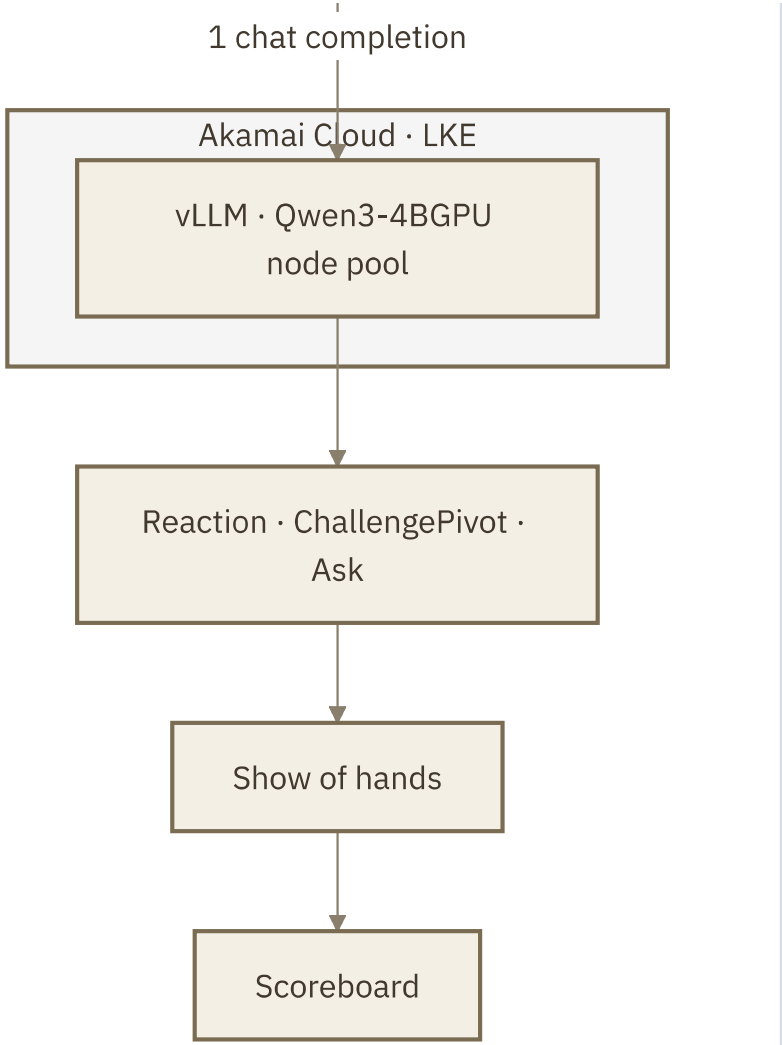
FOUNDER	IDEA	VOTES	VERDICT
Jordan	LinkedIn for dogs	15 / 4	Funded
Maya	Toaster app that screams when your toast is done	6 / 6	Tie
Leo	Blockchain-verified socks	2 / 18	Ditched

UNDER THE HOOD

Everything runs on Akamai Cloud



COMPUTE	Akamai Cloud Kubernetes (LKE) with a GPU node pool
SERVING	vLLM, OpenAI-compatible API
MODEL	Qwen3-4B, open weights, no third-party AI API
APP	Python 3 with the official openai



	package, no framework
ACCESS	`kubectl port-forward` to the vLLM service

DESIGN CHOICES

Small model, tight format, fast answers

One call per pitch

A single chat completion returns the

Four fixed sections

The system prompt forces the same four

Thinking switched off

Qwen3 reasons out loud by default.

whole verdict. No chains, no agents, nothing to fail mid-show.

headings every time, so a 4B model stays readable on a projector.

Turning that off keeps each answer to a few seconds on stage.

Humans decide

The model never picks the winner. The audience does, which keeps the room engaged.

```
client.chat.completions.create(
    model="Qwen/Qwen3-4B",
    messages=[{"role": "system", "content": SYSTEM_PROMPT},
              {"role": "user", "content": f"Startup pitch: {idea}"}],
    max_tokens=400, temperature=0.9,
    extra_body={"chat_template_kwargs": {"enable_thinking": False}},
)
```

PRESENTING IT · ABOUT 3 MINUTES

Talk track

0:00	"Who here has a terrible startup idea? I need three founders." Pick three volunteers before you explain anything.
0:20	"This is Victoria Vault, an AI investor running on Qwen3-4B on our own Akamai GPU cluster. She'll judge your pitch. You'll decide if she's right."
0:40	Run the three pitches. Read each section aloud, then call the vote: "Hands up to fund. Hands up to ditch."

	About 40 seconds per pitch, including the vote.
2:40	Show the scoreboard and crown the winner.
2:50	"One LLM call per pitch, self-hosted open model, vLLM on Akamai LKE, about 140 lines of plain Python."

WHAT'S NEXT

Where it goes from here

- A web page with a text field and a big-screen view, so the audience can see each verdict appear.
- Audience voting from their phones instead of counting hands.
- Several investor personalities on one panel, each one model call.
- A public endpoint behind a NodeBalancer with TLS, so it runs without a port-forward.